

project—yes, open source can exist on Windows too!), a system manager, and pretty much everything your home PC would need. Each distribution—at least the bigger ones—have their own professional support for enterprise users, besides “community” support by way of which enthusiast developers and peers lend support if you need any.

Now whatever your distribution, you’ll most likely be running either the KDE (K Desktop Environment) or GNOME (GNU Network Object Modeling Environment) desktop environment. These are essentially GUIs that present the various commands available to the user. KDE was originally made for the UNIX operating system, while GNOME came as part of the GNU project.

One of the friendly (sometimes serious) debates is on how GNOME is pronounced—either “guh-nome” or “nome.” Well, we aren’t taking sides here, so go ahead and call it what you want! You can find more information on desktop environments in the Chapter 4, which deals with the X-Windows system.

1.7 Live CDs

Play it safe before you venture out

Installing an OS requires formatting all or part of your hard disk with a particular file system. The installation process is often time-consuming, even if it’s easy. So, for someone who wants to just get a feel of an OS, Linux Live CDs come as a blessing.

Live CDs are like boot floppies. All you need to do is boot off a Live CD, and you will have Linux up and running! It’s as simple as that—really! This is a great way to experiment and feel your way around the myriad of options in Linux before you sit down to install and run them from your hard disk. Earlier, Linux installation used to be a pain in the, er... brain, but thankfully, much of that has been sorted out. However if the thought of installation